Although a bit irritated at this unwarranted intrusion, out of courtesy to a senior officer, I nevertheless gave him a briefing of the situation and we had a steaming cup of tea, warming our hands on the stainless-steel glasses. He left a few minutes later, wishing me luck. Imagine my surprise when a few weeks later he was posted as the GOC. I thanked my stars that I had been polite and briefed him properly. I think this incident had made a favourable impression on him, not only of the unit but also about me, having seen me there, crouched in the snow, leading from the front.

On one occasion, we had cordoned off a house in the heart of Srinagar. I was directing the proceedings from the first floor of an adjacent under-construction house. Maj Gen Dalbir joined me in the room overlooking the target house, standing behind the central pillar and peeking out through the windows on either side. A burst of fire came in through the windows, struck the wall in the rear and the splinters hit Maj Gen Dalbir in the back and rear. Nothing serious, but we had to pause the operation to administer some first aid, with me hinting to him that I had the situation under control and that he could return to his HQ. He left shortly thereafter, with strict instructions that this incident should not be part of the official after-action report. It would be bad for morale, he said, if reports went out that a GOC had been injured.

My class fellow, Col Sarwottam Hasabnis, was at the time commanding his unit (5 JAT) on the LC, as part of 19 Inf Div. Whenever he used to go on leave, he would stop over at my HQ before going to the airport to catch the civil flight to Delhi and onwards to Pune. On more than one occasion, I would get a call while we were at lunch that an encounter had broken out, which required my immediate presence. I would bid a quick farewell and move to the site, coming back only

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